YET I WILL REJOICE · SESSION 1

How Long, LORD?

Habakkuk 1:1–17

TO GET STARTED

Think of a time you waited a long while for an answer – an exam result, a reply to an application, news from a doctor. What was the waiting like, and what did you do with it?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Habakkuk lived in Judah at the end of the seventh century BC, probably under King Jehoiakim (about 609–598 BC), after the godly King Josiah had died at Megiddo and the country slid back into corruption, violence and bribed courts. At the same time Babylon was rising: Nineveh fell in 612 BC and Egypt was beaten at Carchemish in 605 BC. Most prophets speak to the people for God; Habakkuk speaks to God for the people. Tonight we hear a conversation: his first complaint (1:2–4), God's shocking answer (1:5–11) and his second complaint (1:12–17).

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 1:1–2

1 The oracle that Habakkuk the prophet saw.

2 How long, LORD, shall I cry for help,
and you do not hear?
I cry out to you, "Violence!"
and you do not save.

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 1:3–3

3 Why do you make me see wickedness,
and why do you look on misery?
Destruction and violence are before me;
there is strife, and contention rises up.

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 1:4–4

4 Therefore instruction grows numb,
and justice never comes forth.
For the wicked surrounds the righteous;
therefore justice comes forth twisted.

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 1:5–5

5 See among the nations, and look;
be astonished – be astounded!
For I am doing a work in your days
that you would not believe if it were told.

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 1:6–7

6 For look, I am raising up the Chaldeans,
that bitter and impetuous nation,
who march across the breadth of the earth
to take possession of dwellings that are not their own.
7 Terrible and dreadful is he;
from himself come forth his justice and his dignity.

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 1:8–8

8 His horses are swifter than leopards
and fiercer than wolves at evening.
His horsemen gallop on,
his horsemen come from far away;
they fly like a vulture that hurries to devour.

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 1:9–9

9 All of them come for violence;
the set of their faces is forward,
and he gathers captives like sand.

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 1:10–10

10 He mocks at kings,
and rulers are a joke to him.
He laughs at every fortress;
he heaps up dust and captures it.

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 1:11–11

11 Then he sweeps on like the wind and passes by,
and he becomes guilty –
he whose strength is his god.

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 1:12–12

12 Are you not from of old, LORD,
my God, my Holy One?
We will not die.
LORD, you have appointed him for judgment;
O Rock, you have established him to reprove.

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 1:13–13

13 Your eyes are too pure to see evil,
and you cannot look on misery.
Why do you look on the treacherous
and keep silent when the wicked swallows up
one more righteous than he?

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 1:14–15

14 You make people like the fish of the sea,
like crawling things that have no ruler.
15 He brings them all up with a hook,
he drags them away in his net
and gathers them in his dragnet;
so he is glad and rejoices.

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 1:16–17

16 Therefore he sacrifices to his net
and burns incense to his dragnet,
for through them his portion is fat
and his food is rich.
17 Is he then to keep emptying his net
and go on killing nations without sparing?

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

חָמָס

chamas · “violence”

In 1:2 Habakkuk uses two verbs for prayer: shiwwa', the persistent cry for help of someone in distress, and za'aq, the scream of a victim under attack. And in that scream he utters one word: chamas – cruelty, bloodshed and injustice. The same word returns in 1:3 and 1:9: the violence he complains about in Judah is met by the violence of the Chaldeans.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

וְהִתַּמְּהוּ תְּמָהוּ

wehittammehu tamahu · “be astonished – be astounded”

God doubles the verb tamah (1:5). It does not mean being mildly surprised but being paralysed with shock and disbelief. While Habakkuk thought God was doing nothing, God says: “For I am doing a work in your days that you would not believe if it were told.” Acts 13:41 quotes this verse as a warning not to overlook God's saving work in Christ.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

צוּר

tsur · "Rock"

In 1:12 Habakkuk calls God "Rock" – the only time in his book. Before he asks his second "Why?", he anchors himself in who God is: from of old, my God, my Holy One, Rock, with eyes too pure to see evil. While the Babylonians sweep over the earth like a storm, he holds on to the immovable rock face (compare Deuteronomy 32:4).

THE BIG IDEA

God welcomes our honest lament: he is never absent when heaven feels silent, he rules even over the powers that frighten us, and when his answer confuses us we can hold on to who he is – our Rock from of old.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

Habakkuk does not hide his frustration behind pious phrases: “How long, LORD, shall I cry for help, and you do not hear?” Is it allowed to speak to God like this? What is the difference between complaining about God to other people and bringing the complaint directly to God?

Habakkuk 1:2

DISCUSSION · 2/7

“Therefore instruction grows numb, and justice never comes forth.” Where do you see instruction and justice “growing numb” in our society today – and where are you in danger of growing spiritually cold or numb yourself because you are tired of waiting?

Habakkuk 1:3–4

DISCUSSION · 3/7

God's answer is not what Habakkuk expected: “For look, I am raising up the Chaldeans.” Has God ever answered a prayer of yours in a way that caught you off guard, something that first looked like a disaster but later turned out to shape or rescue you?

Habakkuk 1:5–6

DISCUSSION · 4/7

The Chaldean is a law to himself – “from himself come forth his justice and his dignity” – and he is the one “whose strength is his god”. In which areas of daily life do we live as if our own strength, cleverness or control were enough?

Habakkuk 1:7–11

DISCUSSION · 5/7

In his second complaint Habakkuk starts with what he knows about God before he asks what he does not understand: “Are you not from of old, LORD, my God, my Holy One? We will not die.” Which of these truths do you find hardest to hold on to in a deep disappointment? Why?

Habakkuk 1:12–13

DISCUSSION · 6/7

The oppressor treats people “like the fish of the sea”, and “he sacrifices to his net and burns incense to his dragnet”, because it makes his life rich. Where do people today become mere numbers – and which “nets” (work, qualifications, savings, skills) receive the trust that belongs to God alone in our lives?

Habakkuk 1:14–17

DISCUSSION · 7/7

Where in your life or in our world are you crying out right now, “How long?” Have you put that into words before God? Share only what you are comfortable sharing.

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Write your own honest “How long?” prayer this week – no masks, no polished words. Then, like Habakkuk in 1:12, add underneath three things you know for certain about who God is.
- Look at one “net” you rely on (your job, your savings, your skills). Each day this week thank God for it as a gift and tell him in a sentence that your security is in him, not in it.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin with a few minutes of honest lament: let anyone who wishes name, in a sentence, a situation where they are asking “How long?” – in our world or in their own life. Then pray together through the names Habakkuk gives God in 1:12 (from of old, my God, my Holy One, Rock) and ask him to keep your hearts from growing numb. End by praying for people who suffer violence and injustice today.

YET I WILL REJOICE · SESSION 2

Write Down the Vision

Habakkuk 2:1–20

TO GET STARTED

What is the hardest thing for you to wait for in everyday life – a slow queue, a loading screen, a parcel, a reply to a message? What do you usually do while you wait?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Last time Habakkuk asked how a holy God can use the cruel Babylonians to punish Judah (1:12–17). Now he climbs his guard post to wait for God's answer (2:1). The LORD gives him a vision to be written plainly on tablets: it will surely come at the appointed time, and the righteous will live by his faithfulness (2:2–5). Then the peoples oppressed by Babylon take up a taunt-song of five “Woes” that lay bare the empire's greed, pride, bloodshed, cruelty and idolatry (2:6–20).

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 2:1–2

1 I will stand at my guard post
and take my place on the rampart;
I will watch to see what he will say to me
and what I shall answer concerning my reproof.
2 Then the LORD answered me and said:

Write down the vision
and make it plain on the tablets,
so that whoever reads it may run.

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 2:3–4

3 For the vision is still for the appointed time;
it pants toward the end, and it will not deceive.
If it lingers, wait for it,
for it will surely come; it will not delay.
4 Look, he is puffed up – his soul is not upright within him;
but the righteous will live by his faithfulness.

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 2:5–5

5 And moreover, wine is treacherous;
an arrogant man does not stay at home.
He opens his throat wide like the grave;
he is like death and is never sated.
He gathers to himself all the nations
and assembles to himself all the peoples.

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 2:6–6

6 Will not all of these take up a taunt against him,
a mocking song, riddles about him, and say:
Woe to the one who heaps up what is not his own –
how long? –
and loads himself heavy with pledges!

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 2:7–7

7 Will not those who bite you rise up suddenly,
and those who make you tremble wake up,
and you will become plunder for them?

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 2:8–8

8 Because you have plundered many nations,
all who are left of the peoples will plunder you,
because of human blood and violence to the land,
to the city and all who live in it.

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 2:9–10

9 Woe to the one who gains evil gain for his house,
to set his nest on high,
to be snatched from the grip of evil!
10 You have counselled shame for your house
by cutting off many peoples,
and you are sinning against your own life.

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 2:11–12

11 For a stone from the wall will cry out,
and a rafter from the woodwork will answer it.
12 Woe to the one who builds a town with blood
and founds a city on injustice!

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 2:13–14

13 Look, is it not from the LORD of hosts
that peoples toil only for the fire
and nations weary themselves for nothing?
14 For the earth will be filled
with the knowledge of the glory of the LORD,
as the waters cover the sea.

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 2:15–15

15 Woe to the one who makes his neighbour drink,
mixing in your wrath and making him drunk as well,
in order to look on their nakedness!

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 2:16–16

16 You are sated with disgrace instead of glory.
Drink, you too, and show your foreskin!
The cup in the LORD's right hand will come around to you,
and utter disgrace will come upon your glory.

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 2:17–17

17 For the violence done to Lebanon will cover you,
and the destruction of the beasts that terrified them,
because of human blood and violence to the land,
to the city and all who live in it.

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 2:18–18

18 What use is a carved image,
that its maker has carved it,
a cast image and a teacher of lies?
For its maker trusts in what he himself has formed
when he makes mute idols.

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 2:19–19

19 Woe to the one who says to wood, "Wake up!"
"Awake!" to a silent stone.
Can it teach?
Look, it is overlaid with gold and silver,
and there is no breath at all inside it.

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 2:20–20

20 But the LORD is in his holy temple –
silence before him, all the earth!

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

אֱמוּנָה

'emunah · “faithfulness”

2:4 reads “but the righteous will live by his faithfulness”. 'Emunah, from the root 'aman (behind our “Amen”), means steadfastness, reliability, persevering loyalty and unshakeable trust; in Exodus 17:12 Moses' hands stayed 'emunah – steady. The same root stands in 1:5 (“you would not believe”): in Hebrew, believing and being faithful are one family of words. Paul (Romans 1:17; Galatians 3:11) and Hebrews 10:38 (“but my righteous one will live by faith”) read the word as faith – a lifelong, reliable clinging to God's promises.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

כָּבוֹד

kavod · “glory”

The root of kavod means “to be heavy, weighty”; its opposite, qalon, “disgrace” (2:16), comes from “to be light”. Babylon is “sated with disgrace instead of glory”: its power will vanish like a light mist, while the true weight and majesty of God will fill the earth “as the waters cover the sea” (2:14).

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

הַס

has · “silence”

The chapter closes with the sound-word has! – like our “hush!” (2:20). The idols are mute; the living God in his holy temple brings the whole noisy, proud world to silence. Chapter 1 asked why God keeps silent (1:13); chapter 2 ends with Habakkuk himself falling silent in worship.

THE BIG IDEA

While we wait at the guard post, God's promise is sure: the proud will not stand, but the righteous will live by his faithfulness – trusting God until the appointed time, when the earth will be filled with the knowledge of the glory of the LORD.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

“I will stand at my guard post and take my place on the rampart; I will watch to see what he will say to me.” What does your own “guard post” look like? Do you make room to be still and listen – or do you do all the talking?

Habakkuk 2:1

DISCUSSION · 2/7

Habakkuk also waits to hear “what I shall answer concerning my reproof” – he is ready to be corrected. Why is it hard to let God correct our perspective when we are the ones who feel wronged?

Habakkuk 2:1

DISCUSSION · 3/7

God tells Habakkuk: “Write down the vision and make it plain on the tablets, so that whoever reads it may run.” Which promises from God's Word, or lessons from your past, do you need to “write down” to carry you through dark days?

Habakkuk 2:2

DISCUSSION · 4/7

“If it lingers, wait for it, for it will surely come; it will not delay.” How can a promise seem to linger and yet not be late? Has a time of waiting drawn you closer to God or left you discouraged?

Habakkuk 2:3

DISCUSSION · 5/7

Verse 4 shows two ways of living: the one who is puffed up, whose soul is not upright, and the righteous who “will live by his faithfulness”. Romans 1:17 stresses how we become righteous, Galatians 3:11 how we receive life, Hebrews 10:38 how we persevere. Which of these speaks most to you right now – and where do you live with a “puffed-up soul” instead of steadfast trust?

Habakkuk 2:4–5

DISCUSSION · 6/7

The five woes hold up a mirror: heaping up what is not your own (v. 6), setting your nest on high (v. 9), building with blood (v. 12), humiliating others (v. 15), trusting mute idols (vv. 18–19). Which of these temptations do you recognise most in our culture – or in yourself?

Habakkuk 2:6–19

DISCUSSION · 7/7

Peoples “toil only for the fire”, but “the earth will be filled with the knowledge of the LORD, as the waters cover the sea”. And then: “But the LORD is in his holy temple – silence before him, all the earth!” How do these verses change the way you look at the news, and at where your time and energy go?

Habakkuk 2:13–20

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Choose one promise of God and literally write it down this week – on a card, your phone's lock screen or the fridge – where you will read it every day while you wait.
- Take five minutes of silence each day before God with 2:20 in front of you: bring your inner noise, anxiety and complaints to a standstill before you say anything.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin with a minute of silence together, as 2:20 invites. Then pray in twos or threes for the things each of you is waiting for, asking for the steadfast trust of 2:4. End by praying 2:14 together for your town and for the nations: that the earth will be filled with the knowledge of the glory of the LORD.

YET I WILL REJOICE · SESSION 3

Yet I Will Rejoice

Habakkuk 3:1–19

TO GET STARTED

Is there a song, a photo or an object that reminds you of a time when you were carried through something difficult? What does it bring back to you?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Chapter 1 began with a question mark in the dark (1:2); chapter 2 took us to the guard post, where God's promise was written down. Chapter 3 is a prayer-psalm with musical directions at the beginning and the end and three times the word Sela. Habakkuk asks God to bring his work to life (3:2), remembers how God came in power at the exodus, at Sinai and in Joshua's days (3:3–15), trembles at what lies ahead (3:16) – and ends with one of the boldest confessions of faith in Scripture (3:17–19). His circumstances have not improved at all; what has changed is Habakkuk himself.

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 3:1–2

[1] A prayer of Habakkuk the prophet, according to *shigionot*.

[2] LORD, I have heard the report of you;
I fear, LORD, your work.
In the midst of the years, bring it to life;
in the midst of the years, make it known.
In turmoil, remember compassion.

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 3:3–3

3 God came from Teman,
the Holy One from Mount Paran.
Sela
His splendour covered the heavens,
and the earth was full of his praise.

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 3:4–5

4 His brightness was like the light;
rays broke from his hand,
and there his power was veiled.
5 Before him went pestilence,
and plague came forth at his feet.

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 3:6–6

6 He stood and measured the earth;
he looked and made the nations start.
The everlasting mountains were shattered,
the ancient hills sank low;
the ancient ways are his.

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 3:7–7

7 I saw the tents of Cushan under calamity;
the tent curtains of the land of Midian trembled.

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 3:8–8

8 Was it against the rivers that the LORD burned?
Was your anger against the rivers,
or your rage against the sea,
when you rode on your horses,
your chariots of salvation?

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 3:9–9

9 Your bow was laid bare, utterly bare;
sworn were the rods – a word.
Sela
You split the earth into rivers.

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 3:10–10

10 The mountains saw you and writhed;
a torrent of water passed over.
The deep gave its voice;
it lifted its hands on high.

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 3:11–12

11 Sun and moon stood still in their dwelling
at the light of your arrows as they sped,
at the brightness of the flash of your spear.
12 In fury you marched through the earth;
in anger you threshed the nations.

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 3:13–13

13 You went out for the salvation of your people,
for the salvation of your anointed.
You crushed the head of the house of the wicked,
laying bare the foundation up to the neck.
Sela

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 3:14–15

14 With his own rods you pierced the head of his warriors,
who stormed out to scatter me;
their exulting was as if to devour
the poor in a hiding place.
15 You trod the sea with your horses,
the surging of many waters.

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 3:16–16

16 I heard, and my insides trembled;
at the sound my lips quivered.
Rot entered my bones,
and where I stand I tremble.
Yet I will wait quietly for the day of distress
to come up against the people who invade us.

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 3:17–17

17 Though the fig tree does not blossom
and there is no fruit on the vines,
though the olive crop fails
and the terraced fields yield no food,
though the flock is cut off from the pen
and there are no cattle in the stalls –

READ TOGETHER · HABAKKUK 3:18–19

18 yet I will exult in the LORD,
I will rejoice in the God of my salvation.
19 The LORD, the Lord, is my strength;
he makes my feet like those of the deer
and lets me tread on my high places.
For the choir director, on my stringed instruments.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

רַחֵם

rachem · “compassion”

Habakkuk prays: “In turmoil, remember compassion.” (3:2). Rachem is deep, motherly tenderness, related to rechem, “womb”. The word rogez, “turmoil”, is often understood as God's wrath; the same root returns in 3:16, where the prophet himself trembles. He no longer asks God to take away the chastisement, but that God's grace will keep his people alive through it.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

אָעֲלוֹזָה · אָגִילָה

'alaz / gil · "exult / rejoice"

"yet I will exult in the LORD, I will rejoice in the God of my salvation" (3:18). 'Alaz means to triumph, to be exuberantly glad; gil is to shout aloud for joy, perhaps from a root "to go round in a circle", like someone dancing. This is not teeth-gritting acceptance but radiant joy in God himself – outdoing the Chaldean who "is glad and rejoices" over his catch (1:15).

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

אַיָּלוֹת

ayyalot · "deer"

"he makes my feet like those of the deer and lets me tread on my high places" (3:19). Ayyalot are the does, the female deer, which climb steep, dangerous rock ledges with astonishing sureness, without slipping. The LORD does not remove the rocks of the trial; he gives feet to stand on them.

THE BIG IDEA

Remembering what God has done gives hope for what lies ahead: even when every earthly security falls away and our bodies tremble, we can rejoice in the God of our salvation, because our joy rests on who he is, not on what he gives.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

“LORD, I have heard the report of you; I fear, LORD, your work.” Then Habakkuk prays: “In the midst of the years, bring it to life”. Where in your life, family or church do you need God to bring new life and compassion in the middle of a dry season?

Habakkuk 3:2

DISCUSSION · 2/7

In 3:3–15 Habakkuk looks back: the exodus through the sea (vv. 8, 15), Sinai in the south (v. 3), sun and moon standing still in Joshua's days (v. 11). Why does remembering what God has done give hope for the future? What do you remember – and what does the cross and empty tomb of Christ add to this?

Habakkuk 3:3–15

DISCUSSION · 3/7

“You went out for the salvation of your people, for the salvation of your anointed.” The word salvation (yesha') shares its root with the names Joshua and Jesus. How does it help to know that God himself goes out to save?

Habakkuk 3:13

DISCUSSION · 4/7

Habakkuk is honest about his body: “I heard, and my insides trembled; at the sound my lips quivered.” Yet he says: “Yet I will wait quietly for the day of distress”. Do you sometimes feel guilty about anxiety or stress, as if it meant you had no faith? What do you learn from trembling and trust standing side by side?

Habakkuk 3:16

DISCUSSION · 5/7

Verse 17 lists six things – figs, vines, olives, fields, flock, cattle – the whole farm economy from small luxuries to bare survival. If you wrote your own verse 17 in today's terms, how would it sound?

Habakkuk 3:17

DISCUSSION · 6/7

“yet I will exult in the LORD, I will rejoice in the God of my salvation.” Many of us live with an unspoken contract: “I will trust you as long as …”. What is the difference between joy in what God gives and joy in God himself?

Habakkuk 3:18

DISCUSSION · 7/7

Looking back over the whole book – from “How long, LORD?” (1:2) to “Yet” (3:18): what has changed in Habakkuk, and what has changed in you during this series? Share only what you are comfortable sharing.

Habakkuk 3:19

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Write your own verse 17 this week, naming your fears one by one ("Though my savings run out, though …"), and then write 3:18 underneath and pray it aloud each day.
- Make a short list of three times God carried you in the past – your own "3:3–15" – and share one of them with someone this week.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin by thanking God together for what he has done in the past, in Scripture and in your own lives. Then let anyone who wishes name, in a sentence, where in their life “the fig tree does not blossom”, and let the group answer each one by saying together: “yet I will exult in the LORD, I will rejoice in the God of my salvation.” Close by reading 3:19 aloud over one another as a blessing.